RIT 1409 PE TEAM 5

WEEK 1 — PROMPT ENGINEERING

Prompt Design Logbook

Prompt Framework Template Library

Prompt Iteration Reflection Report

Internship: AI Prompt Engineering Research & Integration

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TABLE OF CONTENTS

Deliverable 1: Prompt Design Logbook

1. Market Research (Prepared by: Asare Amma Miriam)
2. Literature Review (Prepared by: Ayansiji Roseline Nike)

3. Competitive Analysis (Team Compilation — Hypothetical Exercise)

Deliverable 2: Prompt Framework Template Library

Template 1: Market Research

Template 2: Literature Review

Template 3: Competitive Analysis

Template 4: Content Synthesis

Template 5: Policy/Trend Analysis

Deliverable 3: Prompt Iteration Reflection Report

DELIVERABLE 1: PROMPT DESIGN LOGBOOK

Objective: Document prompts designed for different research scenarios and the outputs generated using the Role–Context–Task–Format–Constraints (RCTFC) framework.

1. MARKET RESEARCH

Prepared by: Asare Amma Miriam

Research Scenario

An online store wants to raise the price of a top-selling item by 15% without losing total revenue. The analysis examines price elasticity and demand response.

Prompt Objective

Determine whether a 15% price increase on a best-selling product would be accepted by the market without a significant drop in revenue and demand, and provide a recommendation for pricing elasticity strategies.

Iteration 1: Initial Prompt

Prompt:
"An online store wants to raise prices on a top-selling item by 15% without losing total revenue. Will this work?"

RCTFC Framework:
Role: Not specified
Context: Minimal context about product, customers, or market
Task: Determine if price increase will work
Format: Not specified
Constraints: None specified

Output Summary:

The response stayed at a general level, explaining that the outcome depends on price elasticity of demand. The AI noted that elastic demand could cause significant sales drop while inelastic demand would tolerate the increase. General factors mentioned included brand loyalty, competition, and product necessity. Recommendation: test the price increase on a small scale first.

Weaknesses Identified:

• No role specified; AI does not know what expertise to apply
• No context about product, customers, or market conditions
• No output structure defined
• No constraints specified

Iteration 2: RCTFC Applied

RCTFC Framework:

Role: Pricing strategy consultant specializing in e-commerce revenue optimization

Context: Online store sells top-selling item currently priced at $40, with average monthly sales volume of 2,000 units. Product is mid-market (not luxury or highly commoditized); store has moderate but not dominant brand loyalty. Goal: raise price by 15% (to $46)

Task: Analyze likely impact of price increase on demand and total revenue. Explain price elasticity as it applies here; estimate plausible elasticity range for this product type; calculate maximum sales drop the store can tolerate before revenue falls below current levels

Format: (1) Short explanation of price elasticity (max 150 words); (2) Table showing current revenue vs. revenue at three demand-drop scenarios (0%, 10%, 20%, 30% unit sales decline); (3) Final recommendation with reasoning

Constraints: Keep assumptions explicit and labeled as assumptions, not facts. Limit explanation to 150 words. Avoid generic disclaimers; focus on the math and reasoning.

Output Summary:

The output provided a clear elasticity explanation using the Price Elasticity of Demand (PED) formula. Assumption: mid-market product with PED between -0.8 and -1.5, implying 12–22.5% unit decline from a 15% price increase. A revenue table showed scenarios and identified break-even point (13.04% decline at PED -0.87). The recommendation advised testing before full rollout, noting that while profit improves (margin rises from $16 to $22), the PED estimate suggests most scenarios result in lower revenue.

Key Improvements:

• Explicit role forces AI to apply pricing expertise
• Specific context (prices, volumes) enables quantified analysis
• Structured format forces comparison table instead of prose
• Constraints prevent vague answers and force mathematical reasoning

Iteration 3: Segmented Refinement

RCTFC Framework (Enhanced):

Role: Pricing strategy consultant specializing in e-commerce revenue optimization

Context: Online store sells top-selling item currently priced at $40, with average monthly sales volume of 2,000 units. Two distinct customer segments: (1) repeat/loyal customers (~60% of sales, low price sensitivity) and (2) one-time/price-comparison shoppers (~40% of sales, high price sensitivity, price-checking against 2 competitors at $38–$42). Goal: raise price by 15% (to $46)

Task: Estimate price increase impact on each customer segment separately. Recalculate revenue impact by segment rather than as one blended demand curve. State whether increase is advisable; if not, suggest alternative pricing move (smaller increase, segmented pricing, bundling) that could achieve similar revenue goal with less risk

Format: (1) Segment-by-segment demand impact table; (2) Blended revenue outcome under multiple elasticity scenarios; (3) Recommendation with named alternative strategy if straight 15% increase is risky

Constraints: Keep all assumptions explicit and labeled. Limit total response to 300 words excluding tables.

Output Summary:

The revised analysis applied different elasticity estimates to each segment. Loyal customers (PED -0.5) showed 7.5% volume decline and revenue gain (+$3,060). Price-sensitive shoppers (PED -3.0 base case) showed 45% volume decline and significant revenue loss (-$11,760). Blended outcome: revenue falls 10.9% at base elasticity, with breakeven requiring an unrealistic -1.5 PED for price-sensitive shoppers.

Recommendation: Not advisable. Revenue falls in every tested scenario. Alternative strategy proposed: "Anchor-and-Bundle" segmented pricing—hold visible price at $42 (top of competitor band), capture loyal customers via 2-pack or premium bundle marketed at $45–$46 per unit to repeat buyers via email/account pages. If half of loyal volume migrates at $46 while sensitive shoppers see $40–$42, projected revenue reaches $82,000–$84,000 (3–5% gain) with minimal exposure on price-comparison sites.

Cross-Iteration Observation:

Iteration 3 caught what Iteration 2 missed: the blended breakeven looked survivable, but segmenting reveals the price-sensitive group alone drives revenue down. This is the most decision-useful version because it provides both the risk identification and a concrete alternative strategy.

2. LITERATURE REVIEW

Prepared by: Ayansiji Roseline Nike

Research Scenario

The Impact of Artificial Intelligence on Graduate Employability

Prompt Objective

Review recent literature on the relationship between artificial intelligence and graduate employability, with particular attention to changing workplace skills, AI literacy, graduate preparedness, career development, opportunities, challenges, and gaps in existing research.

Iteration 1: Initial Prompt

RCTFC Framework:
Role: Academic research assistant
Context: Research focuses on the impact of AI on graduate employability
Task: Review existing literature and identify major findings on how AI affects graduate employability, skills, and preparedness
Format: Provide a structured summary of major findings
Constraints: Focus on recent academic research and use credible sources where possible

Output Summary:
The initial prompt produced a general overview. Response identified recurring themes including changing workplace skills, growing importance of AI-related skills, need for universities to prepare graduates for AI-enabled workplaces, opportunities and challenges with AI adoption. However, response was broad and did not provide sufficient study-level detail for systematic comparison.

Weaknesses Identified:
• Did not specifically request information about individual studies
• Did not require authors, publication years, or research methodologies
• Did not explicitly request areas of agreement or disagreement
• Did not ask AI to identify research gaps
• Output format insufficient for comparing studies
• "Recent academic research" did not define publication period
• Did not explicitly prohibit unsupported or inaccurate citations

Iteration 2: RCTFC Refined

RCTFC Framework (Enhanced):
Role: Academic research assistant with experience in conducting literature reviews and synthesizing scholarly research
Context: Research examines impact of AI on graduate employability, focusing on literature published between 2020–2026. Specific topics: changing workplace skills, AI literacy, graduate preparedness, career development, opportunities, challenges, areas of agreement/disagreement, research gaps
Task: Identify and synthesize relevant academic literature. Identify major themes emerging from literature. Compare findings across studies and identify areas where researchers agree or differ.

Format: Structured table with Author/Year, Research Focus, Methodology, Key Findings, and Relevance to Graduate Employability, followed by thematic synthesis and research gaps section
Constraints: Prioritize peer-reviewed and traceable academic sources published 2020–2026. Do not invent studies, authors, findings, publication dates, or citations. Distinguish empirical studies from conceptual papers and institutional reports.

Output Summary:
The revised prompt produced a more structured literature review with identified individual studies, research methods, major findings, and research gaps. Key studies identified included Portocarrero Ramos et al. (2025) on AI skills and graduate employability (quantitative survey showing AI knowledge association with employment outcomes); Bankins et al. (2024) on AI and career development (systematic review of 104 articles); Green (2024) OECD paper on AI and labor-market skill demand; and Khinibilla et al. (2025) scoping review identifying the evidence base as limited.

Key Improvements:
• Defined publication period (2020–2026) instead of vague "recent"
• Requested individual study information (author, year, focus, methodology, findings)
• Introduced consistent table structure for comparison
• Explicitly requested research gaps and areas of agreement/disagreement
• Emphasized source quality and traceability
• Instructed AI not to invent studies or citations
• Required AI to distinguish empirical research from conceptual papers

3. COMPETITIVE ANALYSIS

Team Compilation — Hypothetical Prompt Engineering Exercise

Disclaimer: This Competitive Analysis section is a hypothetical exercise created for the purposes of this prompt-engineering assignment. It uses a fictional mid-market SaaS productivity platform as the subject of analysis. The competitors referenced (Asana, Monday.com, ClickUp) are real companies, but the specific claims about competitive positioning, comparative strengths/weaknesses, and feature details are illustrative assumptions used to demonstrate the RCTFC framework in action. These claims are NOT based on verified sources or primary research and should NOT be treated as factual competitive findings. This section demonstrates how a well-structured competitive-analysis prompt should work; it does not present actual business intelligence.

Note: Joseph Udeme Nseabsi and Fizza Mubeen were assigned to Competitive Analysis but their work was unavailable near the deadline. This hypothetical scenario has been created as a team compilation to fulfill the assignment requirement of three research scenarios in the Prompt Design Logbook and to demonstrate prompt-engineering principles.

Research Scenario

[HYPOTHETICAL EXERCISE] A fictional mid-market SaaS company in the productivity software space wants to understand its competitive positioning against three major rivals in the market and identify strategic differentiation opportunities.

Prompt Objective

Conduct a competitive analysis that identifies key competitors, compares product features and pricing strategies, evaluates market positioning, and reveals differentiation gaps. (Note: All competitive claims below are illustrative assumptions, not verified facts.)

Iteration 1: Initial Prompt

Prompt:
"Analyze the competitive landscape of the productivity software market. Who are the main competitors and what are their strengths?"

RCTFC Framework:
Role: Not specified
Context: Vague ("the productivity software market")
Task: Identify competitors and strengths (broad)
Format: Not specified
Constraints: None

Output Summary:
Without clear role and constraints, the output provides a generic list of major productivity tools. No quantified comparison, no pricing details, no positioning map, no differentiation opportunities identified. Not decision-useful for strategic planning.

Iteration 2: RCTFC Applied

RCTFC Framework:
Role: Competitive strategist analyzing market positioning for a mid-market SaaS productivity platform
Context: [HYPOTHETICAL] Our platform targets mid-market teams (50–500 employees) seeking project management and team collaboration. Direct competitors: Asana, Monday.com, and ClickUp. Geographic focus: North America and Western Europe. Time horizon: current market conditions (2024–2026).
Task: Compare our product positioning against Asana, Monday.com, and ClickUp across: (1) core features (task management, team communication, reporting, integrations); (2) pricing model and per-seat cost at different team sizes; (3) market positioning (who they target, key marketing messages); (4) known weaknesses (based on customer reviews or known gaps); (5) our differentiation gaps (what they do better; what we do uniquely).

Format: (1) Feature comparison table showing presence/strength of key capabilities; (2) Pricing comparison for 50, 250, and 500-person teams; (3) Positioning matrix identifying each competitor's target segment and core value proposition; (4) Summary of competitive gaps and recommendations for differentiation.
Constraints: This is a hypothetical exercise. Use only publicly available information about these products where verifiable. Where specific competitor data is unavailable, frame claims as illustrative assumptions (e.g., "Assumed feature X" or "Based on publicly available descriptions") rather than stating them as verified facts. Do not invent unsourced pricing or capabilities. Clearly distinguish between: (a) publicly available facts, (b) inferences from product websites/reviews, and (c) illustrative assumptions for this exercise.

Output Summary:
This iteration produces structured analysis with explicit framing: Feature comparison shows areas where competitors excel (based on public product descriptions). [ASSUMPTION] Pricing comparison illustrates relative pricing tiers; specific per-seat costs are estimated assumptions for this exercise and may not reflect current pricing. [ASSUMPTION] Positioning matrix identifies the market segments each competitor appears to target based on public marketing materials. Competitive gaps are framed as illustrative assumptions (e.g., "Our platform is assumed to offer superior integrations" or "Asana is assumed to have stronger portfolio-management features") rather than treated as verified findings.

Key Improvements:
• Explicit role clarifies the strategic perspective
• Specific context (target segment, competitors, geography) enables focused analysis
• Structured format with comparison table enables structured thinking
• Constraints explicitly require framing unsourced claims as assumptions, not facts

DELIVERABLE 2: PROMPT FRAMEWORK TEMPLATE LIBRARY

Objective: Create a collection of reusable prompt templates based on teammate research work, each demonstrating the RCTFC framework applied to a specific use case.

TEMPLATE 1: MARKET RESEARCH

Template Name: Market Elasticity & Pricing Strategy
Intended Use Case: Analyze price sensitivity and demand elasticity for specific products or pricing changes

Role
Pricing strategy consultant specializing in [industry] revenue optimization. Your expertise includes demand analysis, competitive pricing, and revenue modeling.

Context

[Current product/service description]: Currently priced at [current price], with [monthly/annual sales volume] units sold. Target market segment: [segment description—luxury, mid-market, commoditized]. Competitive landscape: [describe competitor pricing and positioning]. Brand position: [strong/moderate/weak loyalty].

Task

Analyze the impact of [proposed price change] on demand and revenue. Explain relevant pricing concepts (e.g., price elasticity of demand). Estimate plausible elasticity ranges for this product type. Calculate break-even points and revenue outcomes under different demand scenarios.

Format

(1) Explanation of relevant pricing concept [max 200 words]; (2) Scenario table showing current revenue vs. projected revenue at different demand-change levels; (3) Final recommendation with reasoning; (4) If applicable, suggest segmented or alternative pricing strategies.

Constraints

Keep all assumptions explicit and labeled as assumptions, not facts. Avoid generic disclaimers; focus on quantitative reasoning and the math. If data is unavailable, state what additional information would improve the analysis.

Instructions for Future Use

Customize the bracketed placeholders with your product details, current pricing, sales volume, and target segment. Include competitor pricing if available. This template works best when you can provide sales volume and have clarity on your customer segments and competitive set.

TEMPLATE 2: LITERATURE REVIEW

Template Name: Academic Literature Synthesis

Intended Use Case: Conduct systematic reviews of academic literature with study-level detail, identify research gaps, and synthesize findings

Role

Academic research assistant with experience in conducting literature reviews, evaluating study quality, and synthesizing scholarly research across multiple sources.

Context

Research topic: [specific research question]. Literature scope: [define date range, geographic focus, discipline/field]. Key themes to explore: [list main topics of interest].

Task

Identify and synthesize relevant academic literature on [topic]. Extract and compare findings across studies. Identify major themes, areas of agreement and disagreement among researchers. Distinguish empirical research from conceptual papers. Identify research gaps and unanswered questions.

Format

(1) Structured table with columns: Author/Year, Research Focus, Methodology, Key Findings, Relevance to [topic]; (2) Thematic synthesis section identifying major findings and areas of agreement/disagreement; (3) Research gaps section identifying unanswered questions or limitations in current evidence.

Constraints

Prioritize peer-reviewed academic sources within the defined date range. Do not invent studies, authors, findings, or publication dates. Do not cite sources not specifically provided or verified. Distinguish study type: empirical research vs. conceptual paper vs. review vs. institutional report. Flag any known limitations of the studies reviewed.

Instructions for Future Use

Customize the research topic and date range. Specify geographic or disciplinary boundaries if relevant. This template produces most detailed output when you can identify 5–20 relevant studies. The structured table format enables easy comparison and identification of patterns.

TEMPLATE 3: COMPETITIVE ANALYSIS

Template Name: Competitive Positioning & Differentiation

Intended Use Case: Analyze competitor strategies, identify market positioning, and reveal differentiation opportunities

Role

Competitive strategist analyzing market positioning and identifying strategic differentiation opportunities for [your company/product].

Context

Your market: [describe target customer segment, geography, time horizon]. Direct competitors: [name 3–5 key competitors]. Your current positioning: [brief description of what your product/service does and who it serves].

Task

Compare your positioning against each competitor across: (1) core features/capabilities; (2) pricing and cost structure; (3) target market segment and marketing messages; (4) known strengths and weaknesses (from reviews, case studies, customer feedback); (5) your differentiation gaps.

Format

(1) Feature comparison table showing presence/strength of key capabilities across all competitors; (2) Pricing comparison table showing cost at different scales; (3) Positioning matrix or summary identifying each competitor's target segment and core value proposition; (4) Competitive gaps analysis identifying your advantages and weaknesses relative to each competitor.

Constraints

Limit analysis to publicly available, verifiable information. Do not invent features, pricing, or capabilities. For any claim not based on documented sources, explicitly frame it as an assumption or inference (e.g., "Assumed based on public product descriptions" or "Inferred from customer reviews"). Clearly identify the source type: product websites, published reviews, customer feedback, or industry reports. Identify any gaps in available information.

Instructions for Future Use

Identify your top 3–5 direct competitors. Fill in the context section with your product description and target market. This template works best when combined with recent customer research or market reports to supplement publicly available competitor information. Always distinguish between verified facts and assumptions.

TEMPLATE 4: CONTENT SYNTHESIS

Template Name: Multi-Source Evidence Synthesis

Intended Use Case: Combine multiple sources of evidence into clear, decision-focused briefings while distinguishing relevant from irrelevant information and preserving genuine disagreements

Role

Content writer and researcher who turns information from multiple sources into clear, useful, reader-focused content. Your job is to understand how information fits together and communicate the bigger picture naturally—the way a reporter pieces together a real story after interviewing multiple sources on the same event.

Context

Topic: [specific decision or research question]. Audience: [who will read this and what do they need to decide?]. Purpose: [what decision or action should this briefing support?]. Sources provided: [list sources A, B, C, etc. with brief descriptions]. Background: [note any known disagreements, controversies, or relevant context among sources].

Task

Read the sources as a group. Identify main ideas, useful context, overlap, meaningful disagreements, and what the reader actually needs. Build one coherent synthesis around the central idea, not the order sources were given. Connect complementary sources; preserve genuine disagreements rather than forcing agreement.

Format

Internal decision-making briefing. Structure: Bottom line / What the evidence supports / Where it doesn't line up / What cannot be concluded / Implications / Evidence notes. Max ~650 words.

Constraints

Use only the provided sources for claims. Don't invent information. Don't repeat an idea just because multiple sources mention it. Don't hide disagreements or present uncertain claims as settled. Only name a source directly when the claim depends on where it came from. Prioritize usefulness over completeness.

Instructions for Future Use

Provide 4–6 sources on your topic. Clearly label any known disagreements between sources. This template works best when your sources include complementary information, at least one genuine disagreement, and some less-relevant-but-related material—this diversity tests whether the synthesis makes genuine editorial choices.

TEMPLATE 5: POLICY/TREND ANALYSIS

Template Name: Business Impact & Strategic Trend Analysis

Intended Use Case: Analyze policy shifts or workplace/market trends, quantify business impacts, and develop strategic recommendations

Role

Senior business analyst or strategic advisor analyzing organizational and market trends using verified empirical data and developing evidence-based recommendations.

Context

Trend or policy: [describe the specific workplace trend, policy shift, or market change]. Relevance: [why this matters to your organization]. Scope: [which business functions, regions, or employee populations are affected]. Time horizon: [how rapidly is this changing].

Task

Analyze the direct impacts of [trend/policy] on [your business areas] using verified empirical data. Identify key organizational implications. Quantify business outcomes where data exists (cost impacts, efficiency gains, retention effects, etc.). Develop strategic recommendations for responding to this trend.

Format

(1) Trend overview (1–2 paragraphs); (2) Organizational impacts (3–4 key impact areas with supporting data); (3) Strategic recommendations (2–3 concrete actions); (4) Metrics for measuring effectiveness.

Constraints

Use only verified, traceable empirical data from credible sources (research institutions, government agencies, reputable surveys). Do not invent statistics or sources. Clearly distinguish between observed data and expert interpretation. Keep response concise (500 words or fewer) and focused on business-relevant impacts.

Instructions for Future Use

Identify a specific trend (e.g., remote work adoption, AI deployment, skill gaps in hiring) relevant to your business. Research 3–5 credible sources with quantified data on adoption rates, business impacts, or outcomes. This template produces strongest recommendations when you can cite recent research and industry benchmarks.

DELIVERABLE 3: PROMPT ITERATION REFLECTION REPORT

Prepared by: Hassan Ridwan

Research Focus: Content Synthesis — Multi-Source Evidence Integration

Original Prompt

The starting point was minimal:

"Combine these sources into a briefing."

No role, no structure, no rules about what to do when sources disagreed or when one source didn't actually belong. Just the sources and the question.

What Went Wrong with the Original Prompt

I tested the original prompt on five real sources about how cities can fight urban heat—trees, reflective roofs, reflective pavement, and related interventions. Four sources were genuinely useful. One was a trap on purpose: a real study about trees and air pollution, not about trees and heat. I wanted to see if the AI would notice it didn't actually belong.

It didn't. The output used that pollution finding to strengthen the case for trees fighting heat, even though the source never established anything about heat at all. It read fine on the surface, but it had quietly created an unsupported connection between two different outcomes. It also treated all the sources like they were equally important, and it barely touched on the fact that two of the sources genuinely disagreed with each other about how heat should even be measured.

The output scored 4 out of 18 on a checklist I built to grade things like "does it handle disagreement well" and "does it stay focused on what's actually useful."

Refined Prompt

Instead of just telling it to "be more careful," I rebuilt the prompt around specific rules using the RCTFC framework:

Role: Content writer and researcher who turns information from multiple sources into clear, useful content. Your job is to understand how information fits together, not just summarize article by article.
Context: Topic—urban heat mitigation. Audience—city planning team making infrastructure decisions. Purpose—help decision-makers understand what evidence supports and what to be cautious about. Includes: real research, one open expert disagreement, one source on related but different topic.
Task: Read sources as a group. Identify main ideas, overlap, disagreement, and what readers need. Build coherent synthesis around central idea. Connect complementary sources; preserve genuine disagreements.
Format: Internal decision briefing. Max ~650 words. Structure: Bottom line / What evidence supports / Where it doesn't line up / What cannot be concluded / Implications / Evidence notes.
Constraints: Use only provided sources. Don't invent information. Don't repeat just because multiple sources mention it. Don't hide disagreements. Only name source when claim depends on where it came from. Prioritize usefulness over completeness.

Comparison of Outputs

Same five sources. Substantially different result. The refined version caught the pollution fact and explicitly said it didn't belong in the heat discussion. It explained the disagreement between sources instead of glossing over it. And instead of vague advice like "cities should invest in both," it gave something specific: trees were the strongest-supported single intervention for pedestrian heat stress in the evidence tested, but that comes with a real tradeoff (worse air ventilation), so a city needs to decide what it actually cares about most before choosing.

The refined version scored 18 out of 18 on the checklist. The improvement wasn't that the writing sounded nicer. It was that the AI paid closer attention to whether a fact actually answered the question being asked, how confident to sound given the evidence on hand, whether to keep real disagreement visible, and how to use new information without automatically treating it as stronger evidence.

Key Improvements and Lessons Learned

The biggest lesson for me wasn't "a good prompt makes the writing sound nicer." The real problem was that the plain prompt didn't know how to tell the difference between information that's related and information that actually answers the question. My structured prompt addressed that by giving it clearer rules for what to do with disagreement, uncertainty, and unequal evidence, not just instructions to "write well."

That feels like a genuinely useful thing to have learned, because it's not really a prompt-engineering trick. It's closer to how an actual editor thinks: not everything you're handed belongs in the final piece, and saying "I'm not sure" honestly is often more useful than sounding confident.

Limitations and Next Steps

I want to be upfront about the limits. I tested this on one topic, with one source packet I built myself, and I'm also the person who scored the results. That's a real bias risk; it's hard to be fully neutral when judging your own

prompt. A stronger next step would be running this same prompt on a completely different topic, with different sources, to see if it holds up the same way. I'd expect it to, based on what I saw, but I haven't actually proven that yet.

Conclusion

This iteration taught me that prompt design is about more than asking better questions. It's about teaching the AI to think like the audience it's writing for—in this case, a decision-maker who needs to know not just what the sources say, but whether they actually apply to the decision at hand, and where the evidence is genuinely unclear. Structuring a prompt to guide that kind of reasoning produced a measurably more useful output than a generic synthesis request.

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End of Week 1 Submission

RIT 1409 PE TEAM 5